

Round ship

- **What?** Cog
- **Who?** Unknown
- **Where and when?** Northern Europe, c. 10th century CE

One of the most common sea vessels in medieval Europe was the “round ship.” A common round ship was the cog. This vessel had a design described as “clinker-built,” meaning that the planks that made up the hull overlapped one another. Cogs were mostly used for trading because they were sturdy, easy to build, and had lots of space for cargo.



Model of a cog

Some cogs were converted into warships and had platforms added to their fore where sailors stood to fire arrows and cannons at enemies.

Treasure ship

Sails were made of strips of bamboo.



Model of Chinese explorer Zheng He's treasure boat

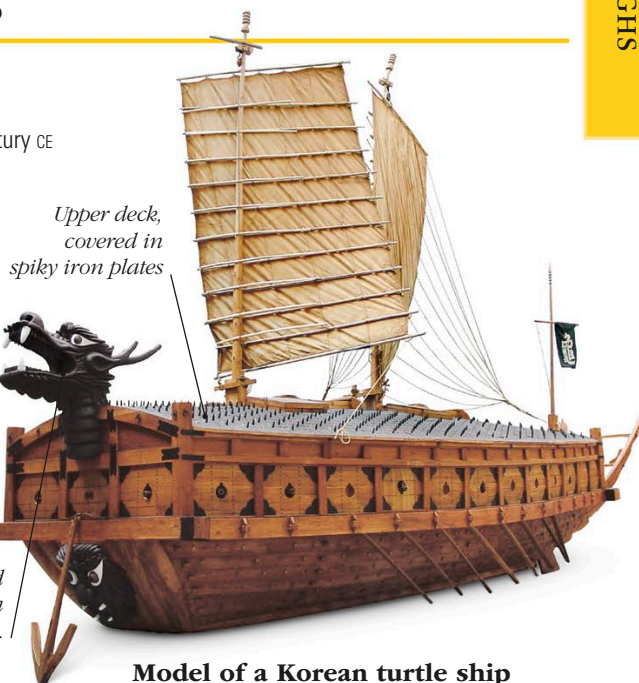
- **What?** Chinese treasure ship
- **Who?** Unknown
- **Where and when?** China, 15th century CE

From 1405 to 1433, the Chinese admiral Zheng He led seven “treasure voyages” across Asia and East Africa. His fleet was made up of dozens of “treasure ships.” They had many sails and may have been around twice the size of European ships in use at the same time. These huge vessels carried treasures that displayed China's wealth and clever technology.

Completely armored ship

- **What?** Korean turtle ship
- **Who?** Unknown
- **Where and when?** Korea, 15th century CE

The Koreans were the first to cover a ship's deck with armor plates to protect it from enemy missiles. Their so-called turtle ships were armed with many cannons. Some were mounted with a dragon's head at the prow that belched out a foggy gas to hide the ship's movements.



Model of a Korean turtle ship

Dragon's head may have belched a cannon.

Long-distance European ship

- **What?** Carrack
- **Who?** Unknown
- **Where and when?** Europe, 15th century CE

By the 15th century, the most common type of ship in Europe was the carrack. It was a large vessel that could sail on rough seas and carry enough provisions for a long journey. The Italian explorer Christopher Columbus used a carrack in 1492 for his voyage to America.



Replica of a medieval carrack